

support," says Yadav, "has ensured that no cheetah has died from hunting, accident or retaliation."

The Union government has shown resolve in continuing with the project even when it met with setbacks, says Dr M.K. Ranjitsinh, who headed the Supreme Court-appointed expert committee on cheetahs. "This is a positive development," he adds, "given the naysayers who condemned the project when the mortalities occurred." The wildlife expert, however, concedes that most deaths—involving a 'violent mating interaction' and infection caused by radio collars—could have been avoided with "better monitoring and management". MP's chief wildlife warden Aseem Shrivastava, however, reasons that "the SC in its order had termed the project as an experiment" and the department has learnt a lot in the first year. "All these takeaways will be put into practice," he says, "to ensure the setbacks are not repeated."

Among the issues that cropped up in the past one year was the lack of coherence between the Centre and the MP government—the state's demand to shift some big cats to Mukundara Park in Rajasthan, for instance, was overlooked by the Union government despite being ratified by the Cheetah Task Force (CTF). Then, there was confusion over committees constituted to manage the cheetahs—in the aftermath of the deaths, the 'headless' CTF was replaced by a steering committee in May. Meanwhile, international experts engaged by the Centre complained about not being consulted.

THOUGH SURVIVAL RATE ABOVE 50% CAN BE TERMED A SUCCESS, MOST FATALITIES COULD HAVE BEEN AVOIDED

The fatalities have also put paid to the plan to develop the region as a major tourist attraction and generate jobs for locals. To make matters worse, on September 5, a Bharatiya Janata Party *yatra* in MP's Neemuch district was pelted with stones by irate villagers protesting the acquisition of land for the second phase of Project Cheetah proposed at Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary. So, a potential man-animal conflict cannot be ruled out. While a team is attached with each cheetah released into the wild, monitoring becomes difficult once the big cat wanders beyond the reserve's open boundaries that it shares with a large number of villages. As the project enters its second year, there's much scope for course correction. ■

By Dhaval Kulkarni

Marking the end of an era, the last of the four iconic diesel-run double-decker buses in the fleet of the Brihanmumbai Electricity Supply and Transport Undertaking, or BEST, will be scrapped mid-September, after completing 15 years of service. Similarly, the three open-deck 'Nilambari' buses that were used for sightseeing will be retiring by October 5. In place of these old buses, the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC)-run road transport undertaking plans to introduce 900 battery-operated, air-conditioned (AC) double-deckers, with 12 already added to its fleet this year and eight more to be inducted soon.

Born as Bombay Electric Supply and Tramways Company in 1905, BEST started its bus service in 1926. The double-decker buses, which were introduced in 1937, remained a major draw for daily commuters due to their utility, and also a tourist attraction due to the thrill of travelling on their upper deck. The Nilambari buses, which were introduced in 1997 in collaboration with the Maharashtra Tourism Development Corporation, ferried over 15,300 tourists on heritage tours this August.

"The double-deckers had a higher passenger-carrying capacity than normal buses, and hence were used for traffic clearance outside busy railway stations during rush hour," shares a senior official of the BEST traffic division, who does not

STEEP OPERATIONAL COSTS AND GROWTH IN TRAFFIC MADE DOUBLE-DECKERS A LIABILITY